India's rehabilitation measures for Sri Lankan Tamils

The construction of 43,000 houses for resettlement and rehabilitation of IDPs in Northern and Eastern Provinces is part of the overall commitment to build 50,000 houses announced by Prime Minister Manmohan Singh during the State visit of the President of Sri Lanka Mahinda Rajapaksa to India, in June 2010, 47,000 have been completed until 2018. USD 350 million grant to build the houses was one of the largest grants by India in any country. Indian PM flagged off a train service at the north-western Sri Lankan town of Talaimannar - the closest point to India - restored after decades of civil war, completing the reconstruction of the entire Northern Province Railway Line. Accompanied by Sri Lankan President Maithripala Sirisena, Modi also unveiled a plaque inaugurating Talaimannar 1650 Pier Railway station.

The newly-constructed 63-km railway track is the last segment of the 265-km long, prestigious Northern Railway Line Reconstruction Project which is being executed by IRCON International Ltd., a Government of India owned company.

During the period of Lal Bahadur Sastri's premiership an agreement was reached between the two nations in resolving the issues of Indian origin Tamils.

India agreed to provide citizenship to two thirds of the people of Indian origin; But the ethnic conflict between native Tamils (Eelam Tamils) and the Singhalese erupted into a protracted civil war, revolting a massive influx of Tamil refugees into India.

Way Ahead

- India can try to get back the island of Kachchatheevu atleast on "lease in perpetuity" or by negotiations.
- Permit licensed Indian fishermen to fish within a designated area of Sri Lankan waters and vice versa.
- There is a glaring need for institutionalisation of fishing in Indian waters by the Government of India so that alternative means of livelihood are provided.
- Government will have to mark up a comprehensive plan to reduce the dependence of Indian fishermen on catch from Palk Bay.

If these social issues can be sorted out. India and Sri Lankan can become prime movers in the regional polity.

10.6 India – Nepal Relations



India and Nepal are geographically close to each other. Nepal's lowland areas are a part of the Gangetic plain and it occupies the central part of the Himalayan foothills and mountains that extends between China and South Asia. Nepal and India share a border of over 1850 kms in the East, South and West with five states, Sikkim, West Bengal, Bihar, Uttar Pradesh and Uttarakhand sharing their borders. Nepal had been earlier the only Hindu Kingdom in the world. However, one –eighth of its population are Buddhists and there is a small population of Muslims and Christians living in the country.

While Nehru always regarded Nepal as a sovereign state, at the same time it was

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